MAIN IDEAS, SUPPORTING IDEAS & THESIS STATEMENTS

Building clear and logical academic essays

Tertiary students • Intermediate English (B1–B2)

Learning outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Identify the main idea of a paragraph or essay.
- Recognise supporting ideas and details.
- Explain the relationship between a thesis statement and body paragraphs.
- Write a focused thesis statement for an academic essay.

1. What is a main idea?

The central point or key message a writer wants to communicate.

TOPIC

Water and electricity wastage

MAIN IDEA

Water and electricity wastage can harm the environment.

The main idea tells readers what the paragraph or essay is mainly about.

2. What are supporting ideas?

They explain, develop or provide evidence for the main idea.

Explanations

Clarify the main idea

Reasons

Explain why something happens

Examples

Show specific situations

Facts or evidence

Provide information to support a claim

Results or consequences

Explain what happens because of something

Example: Main idea and supporting ideas

Topic: Water and electricity wastage

MAIN IDEA

Water and electricity wastage increases household expenses.

SUPPORT 1

Excessive consumption increases monthly utility bills.

Explanation: Families pay more when they use more water and electricity.

SUPPORT 2

Unnecessary use of electrical appliances wastes energy.

Example: Leaving an air conditioner on in an empty room.

SUPPORT 3

Higher utility bills create financial pressure.

Result: Families may have less money for food, transport and other needs.

Every supporting idea should connect clearly to the main idea.

3. What is a thesis statement?

A sentence that presents the main argument or central focus of an essay.

A GOOD THESIS STATEMENT...

- Identifies the topic
- Presents the writer's main point or position
- Indicates the main ideas to be discussed
- Is specific enough to guide the essay

WHERE DOES IT GO?

It is usually placed at the end of the introduction.

Think of the thesis statement as a roadmap for the whole essay.

Thesis statement examples

Notice how each statement gives a focused direction.

Water and electricity wastage

Careless behaviour and a lack of awareness cause wastage, leading to environmental damage and higher living costs.

Procrastination

Poor time management and excessive distractions cause procrastination, resulting in poor academic performance and increased stress.

Bullying

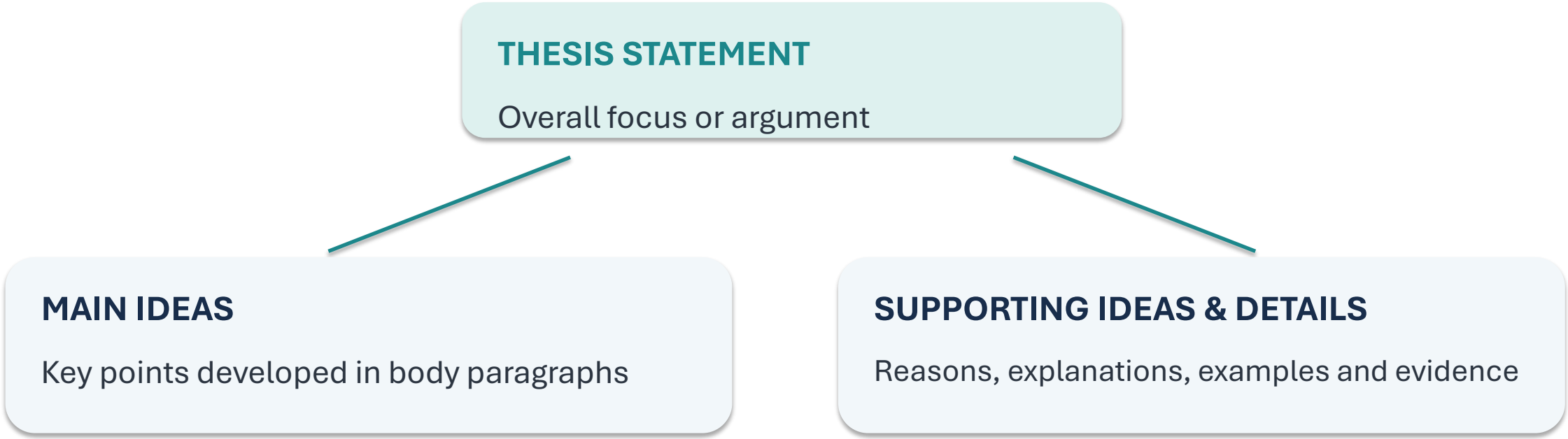
Peer pressure and a lack of empathy can contribute to bullying, resulting in emotional distress and poor academic performance.

Academic stress

Academic stress among university students can be reduced through effective time management, counselling services and better academic support.

How do the three elements work together?

Each element has a different role in a logical essay.



The thesis sets the direction; body paragraphs develop it with relevant support.

Putting it together: Poor time management

Essay topic: Causes, effects and solutions among university students

THESIS STATEMENT

Poor time management is caused by a lack of planning and excessive distractions, leading to poor academic performance and stress; these problems can be addressed through scheduling and prioritisation.

BODY 1 • CAUSES

Lack of planning • Social media distractions • Procrastination

BODY 2 • EFFECTS

Lower-quality assignments • Missed deadlines • Increased stress

BODY 3 • SOLUTIONS

Prepare a schedule • Prioritise tasks • Limit distractions

4. How to write a thesis statement

Use these three steps to move from a topic to a focused claim.

1. Identify the topic

Poor time management among university students.

2. Decide what to say

It has several causes and negative effects.

3. Add key points

It is caused by a lack of planning and distractions, leading to academic difficulties and stress.

Useful thesis statement patterns

Adapt the patterns to suit your essay topic.

Causes and effects

[Topic] is mainly caused by [cause 1] and [cause 2], resulting in [effect 1] and [effect 2].

Problem–solution

[Problem] can be addressed through [solution 1], [solution 2] and [solution 3].

Causes, effects and solutions

[Problem] is caused by [cause 1] and [cause 2], leading to [effect 1] and [effect 2]; however, it can be reduced through [solution 1] and [solution 2].

Practice: Read the paragraph

Identify the main idea, supporting ideas and possible solutions.

READ THE PARAGRAPH

Many university students experience academic stress because they have to complete several assignments and prepare for examinations. Some students also struggle to balance their studies with part-time jobs and family responsibilities. As a result, they may experience tiredness, anxiety and difficulty concentrating in class. Universities can help students manage stress by providing counselling services and organising time-management workshops.

Work individually first, then compare your answers with a partner.

Practice questions

Choose the best answer for each question.

1. What is the main idea?

A. University students should work part-time.

B. Academic stress affects university students and requires appropriate support.

C. Examinations are the only cause of stress.

2. Which is a supporting idea?

A. Students may experience anxiety and difficulty concentrating.

B. All university students should stop studying.

C. Universities should cancel all examinations.

3. Which is the strongest thesis statement?

A. Academic stress is a problem.

B. Many students attend university.

C. Academic stress is caused by heavy workloads and poor time management, resulting in emotional and academic difficulties that can be reduced through better planning and university support.

Answer key & key takeaway

Check your answers, then review the relationship between the concepts.

QUESTION 1

B — Academic stress affects university students and requires appropriate support.

QUESTION 2

A — Anxiety and difficulty concentrating are supporting details.

QUESTION 3

C — It includes causes, effects and solutions.

Remember:

Thesis statement = the essay's direction

Main idea = the key point of a paragraph

Supporting ideas = reasons, explanations, examples and evidence